



Tropical grassland

Often known as savanna, tropical grassland develops in hot parts of the world that have distinct wet and dry seasons. The contrast is dramatic, creating lush green grass for half the year and parched dust for the other half. The rain allows some trees to grow, but only if they can cope with months of drought.

WINTER FIRES

Most savannas lie between the tropical rainforests and the subtropical deserts of Africa, South America, and Australia. As the zone of most intense sunshine moves north and south through the year, it drags storm systems with it, so the rainy season is in summer. But the rest of the year is still very hot, so the grass dries out and often catches fire.



PRECIOUS WATER

Seasonal rain allows many of the savanna grasses to grow very tall. It also fuels the growth of scattered, drought-resistant trees such as eucalyptus and the spiny acacia (shown here). The baobab tree soaks up water during the rainy season and stores it in its swollen trunk.

MASS MIGRATIONS

The Serengeti plains in East Africa are famous for the vast herds of zebras, wildebeests, and gazelles that make long journeys to find new pasture when the dry season stops the grass from growing. The herds trek west and then north to the lush grassland around the Mara River, then move back when the rains return.

DANGER ZONE ►

Migrating wildebeests have to cross the Mara River, where they risk being swept away or attacked by the crocodiles that lie in ambush for them.

